gangs. And yes, you can worship the cow, but how do you deal with the piles of dung on the streets?

A city of a million stories, in 2014 Varanasi was preparing to script an epic political battle. Narendra Modi had been named the BJP candidate from here, a decision that had spurred the AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal to also announce his candidature from the city. The Congress had put up a local strongman (*bahubali* as they call them in eastern UP) and a sitting MLA, Ajay Rai (a section of the UP Congress was hoping Priyanka would stand from Varanasi, but she had no such intention). It was billed as the 'mother of all battles'.

The decision to field Modi from Varanasi was taken as far back as August 2013 even before he was formally made the party's prime ministerial candidate. In a meeting with the RSS, Amit Shah had suggested that Varanasi was the ideal location for Modi to make a pitch as a true national leader. 'Modiji will of course contest from Gujarat, but contesting from Varanasi is even more important,' Shah told the RSS leaders.

The Sangh readily embraced the idea. Varanasi, after all, was the ultimate repository of Hindu civilization. As Diana Eck says in her classic account of Varanasi, *Banaras: City of Lights*, 'Here all the Hindu gods have emerged from the shadows into bold relief, as people have come to understand them, have seen their faces and created their multi-form images.' If Modi was indeed a Hindu Hriday Samrat, then Varanasi was a natural choice as the capital of his kingdom.

Shah had another, more pragmatic political reason for the decision. In his analysis of UP, it was Purvanchal or eastern UP that worried him the most. Of the twenty-five seats in the region, the BJP had won just four in 2009. The SP and BSP had become the dominant forces here. If Mission 272-plus was to be achieved, a dramatic shift was needed in Purvanchal and the adjoining Bhojpur belt in Bihar. What better way than to get the BJP's mascot to contest from the region? 'I was convinced this would enthuse our workers and send out a strong message to the voter,' Shah later told me.

Kejriwal, too, saw political benefit in contesting from Varanasi. Having suddenly, and mistakenly, resigned as Delhi chief minister in mid-February,